

Working Notes for the Millbrook Community Archive

These notes describe how the Millbrook Community Archive is run from week to week. They are written for the volunteers who staff the reading room and process new material, and they assume nothing beyond care, patience and a willingness to write things down. The archive holds the papers of a small town: parish minutes, shop ledgers, school registers, photographs, and the correspondence of families who never expected anyone to read it. None of it is valuable in the auction sense, and all of it is irreplaceable.

The archive exists because the county record office is forty miles away and accepts only what it judges to be of regional significance. A great deal of what matters to Millbrook falls below that line. The founding committee decided in 1987 that the town would keep its own record, in its own building, catalogued by its own people, and that decision has held through three moves of premises and two floods. The collection now runs to roughly nine hundred boxes and grows by thirty or forty a year.

Material arrives in three ways: by donation, by deposit and by rescue. A donation transfers ownership to the archive outright. A deposit leaves ownership with the depositor and lends us custody under written terms. A rescue is anything carried in from a skip, a house clearance or a closing business, and it is treated as a donation until somebody with a better claim appears, which in thirty years has happened twice, both times amicably and both times over a cup of tea.

Every accession, however it arrives, is logged on the day it comes through the door. The log records the date, the source, a one-line description and the name of the volunteer who received it. It does not attempt to describe the contents in detail; that is the job of cataloguing, which happens later and often much later. What the log must do is make certain that nothing can be in the building without a record of how it got there, and of who to ask about it.

Nothing is thrown away on arrival. Duplicates, blank forms and obvious rubbish are set aside in a marked box and reviewed at the quarterly committee meeting, where the decision to dispose is minuted. Volunteers acting alone have in the past discarded items that turned out to be the only surviving copy, and the quarterly rule exists because of those occasions rather than in spite of them. Patience here costs a shelf; haste costs a record, and the shelf is the cheaper of the two.

Depositors are given a receipt and a copy of the deposit terms, and the terms are kept simple: the archive may catalogue, conserve and make the material available for research, and the depositor may withdraw it on three months' notice. Longer or more elaborate agreements have been tried and have always ended in confusion about what was actually promised, usually after the people who made the promise had left the committee and taken their memory of the conversation with them.

The building itself is the old Board School annexe, leased from the town council for a peppercorn rent on a lease that runs to 2047. It has a strong room that was once the coal store, a workroom that was once a classroom, and a reading room that still has the pegs for coats along one wall. Nobody has ever suggested removing the pegs, and nobody should; they are the last of the original fittings, and the caretaker, who has been here longer than the archive, is fond of them.

Cataloguing is the slow heart of the work, and it is deliberately separated from intake so that neither hurries the other. A box may wait a year between the accession log and its catalogue entry. That is acceptable. What is not acceptable is a box that has been partly described, because a partial description looks complete to anyone who did not write it, and the missing half is then invisible for a generation. Finish a box or leave it plainly marked as untouched; there is no useful state in between, and no shame in the second.

The catalogue entry for a box has four parts: a reference number, a title, a date range and a scope note. The reference follows the accession, so it is fixed before the box is opened. The title is the depositor's own name for the material where one exists and a plain description where one does not. The date range is taken from the documents themselves and never guessed. The scope note says what kind of material the box contains and, briefly, what it is about, in that order.

Scope notes are written for a reader who has never seen the box and never will unless the note persuades them to ask for it. Two or three sentences are usually enough. Name the people, the places and the kind of record; say what years are covered thickly and what years are thin; and mention anything a searcher would be glad to know in advance, such as a gap, a fragile item, or a bundle that is written in shorthand. Do not summarise the contents as though writing a history of the town.

Item-level listing, where every letter or photograph gets its own line, is done only for the collections the committee has named. It multiplies the work by a factor of twenty or more and, for most boxes, adds little that a good scope note does not already give. When an item-level list is made, it lives as a separate document attached to the box entry rather than replacing it, so the summary view of the whole collection stays readable to someone in a hurry or a searcher on the telephone.

The reference number is the only thing that must never change. Titles can be corrected, date ranges narrowed, scope notes rewritten, but the number printed on the box, written in the register and quoted in a researcher's footnote has to point at the same material for as long as the archive exists. When two boxes turn out to belong together they are cross-referenced; they are never renumbered, however untidy the result looks.

Every catalogue entry names the volunteer who wrote it and the month it was written. That is not a matter of credit. When an entry turns out to be wrong, which happens, the quickest way to understand the error is to ask the person who made it what they were looking at, and when a whole run of entries shares a misunderstanding it helps to know they came from one hand in one season rather than from everyone at once.

Volunteers new to cataloguing shadow an experienced hand for their first three boxes and are then left to work alone, with the understanding that the first ten entries anyone writes will be read by somebody else before they are filed. That reading is a conversation, not an inspection. Most of what it catches is not error but habit: a tendency to guess at dates, to write scope notes as though the reader already knew the family, or to let an interesting letter distract from the dull ledger that actually tells the story of the box far better than the letter does. The habit is harmless in a reader and expensive in a cataloguer. Neither is a fault in the person.

The strong room is the only part of the building that is kept within a fixed range of temperature and humidity, and it is the only place where catalogued material lives. Uncatalogued accessions wait in the workroom on the metal shelving by the north wall. Nothing is stored on the floor, under a window or on top of a radiator, however briefly, and the volunteer who finds a box in any of those places moves it before doing anything else, including signing in or hanging up a coat.

Boxes are acid-free, lidded and of a single standard size, which means some collections are boxed loosely and a few oversized items are boxed separately with a cross-reference. The standard size is a deliberate constraint. Shelves are spaced for it, the trolley is built for it, and a volunteer can lift any full box safely. A run of odd-sized boxes might save a little space and would cost us all three of those things at once, and permanently, for every volunteer who follows.

Photographs are sleeved individually and stored on edge, not flat, in their own boxes. Negatives are kept apart from prints. Anything on glass is boxed in padded trays and marked as such on the outside, and glass is never carried more than one tray at a time. Newspaper cuttings are photocopied onto archival paper and the copy is filed; the original is kept, but in a separate box, because it will brown and embrittle whatever it touches, and given time it touches everything.

Handling rules are few and firmly kept. Hands are clean and dry; gloves are worn only for photographs. Pencils only in the strong room and the reading room. Documents are supported on the table or on a foam wedge, never held in the air. Bundles are untied and retied with the same tape, and if the tape breaks it is replaced with unbleached cotton tape and the change is noted on the box list. Nothing is ever fastened with a metal clip or a rubber band, and pins are unheard of.

The strong room log records every box that leaves the room and every box that returns, with the time and the volunteer's initials. A box that is out for cataloguing may be out for weeks; that is fine, provided the log says so. What the log prevents is the situation where a box is missing and nobody can say whether it was ever on the shelf, was taken to the reading room, or went home in somebody's bag by mistake, which has happened, exactly once, and was not found for a fortnight.

Pests and water are the two threats that arrive without warning. Sticky traps are checked monthly and the count is written down, because a rising count is the only early signal of an infestation. The water alarm under the strong room floor is tested on the first Saturday of each month, and the person testing it signs the sheet on the door. An unsigned month is treated as an untested month, whatever anyone remembers about it now.

Loans out of the building are rare and are approved only by the committee, in writing, for exhibition by another archive or museum with its own strong room and its own insurance. A loan is packed by two volunteers, photographed item by item before it leaves, and accompanied by a condition report that the borrower countersigns on arrival. Nothing goes on loan to a private individual, a shop window or a school display case, however worthy the occasion, because those are the places from which things do not come back. The rule has been tested twice and has held both times.

The reading room is open on Tuesday and Saturday mornings and at other times by appointment, and it is staffed by two volunteers whenever it is open. One volunteer fetches and returns material

and keeps the strong room log; the other stays in the room. The rule of two is not about suspicion. It is about having someone free to answer a question, find a reference, or deal with a spill while the other is out of the room with a box on the trolley and no hands free.

Researchers sign the visitors' book and fill in a request slip for each box they want to see. Slips are kept for seven years. They are the only record of which material has been consulted, which is useful when a box is later found damaged and essential when a depositor asks who has looked at their family's papers. Slips are filed by date, not by name, so that a search for one box's history means reading a year rather than a name, which is slower and a great deal more reliable.

Requests are fetched in the order they arrive, and no researcher may have more than three boxes on the table at once. A fourth request waits until one of the three goes back. Photography by researchers is permitted for private study without flash and without a tripod, and each photograph is noted on the request slip by box and item. Photocopying is done by volunteers only, on the flat-bed copier, and refused for anything bound, fragile, larger than the platen, or dated before 1900.

Enquiries by post and email are answered within a month, and the answer says either what was found, what was looked at without success, or what would need to be looked at and roughly how long that would take. The archive does not undertake research on a searcher's behalf beyond an hour, but it will always say what it holds and let the searcher decide whether to come. A reply that says only that the material may exist is not an answer to anything, and it is not sent.

Closed material is rare but real. Some deposits carry a closure period set by the depositor, and some records, school registers and medical ledgers in particular, are closed under the archive's own rule for the lifetime of the people named in them. Closed boxes are shelved separately, marked on the outside, and listed in the catalogue with their opening date so that a searcher knows the material exists and when it will open, and can plan a visit accordingly rather than making a wasted journey.

Schools and local groups visit several times a year, and a visit is prepared the week before by pulling a small selection of robust, vivid material onto a table in the workroom rather than taking a party into the strong room. Children handle facsimiles and look at originals. The selection is different each time, chosen for the group, and returned to the shelves the same afternoon with the strong room log completed as usual, school visit or no school visit, and the log initialled by both volunteers.

Volunteers on the desk keep a running list of the questions they could not answer, with the researcher's name and what was tried, and the list is read at each committee meeting. It is the archive's best measure of what it lacks. A question that comes up three times in a year usually means either that a collection is uncatalogued and therefore invisible, or that the town once had a record it no longer has and the archive should be asking around for it before the last person who remembers it is gone. It is also, quietly, the archive's whole collecting policy.

Digitisation is done for access and for insurance, in that order, and never as a substitute for keeping the original. A scanned register lets a searcher read it at home and spares the original from handling; it does not permit the original to be discarded, and any suggestion that it might is referred to the committee with the founding minute attached. Scanning is therefore planned around

what is most asked for and most fragile, not around what is easiest to feed through the machine, which is usually the least wanted material in the room and the least likely to be asked for.

Scans are made at the resolution written on the card by the scanner, saved in the uncompressed master format, and named by reference number followed by a sequence number. A derived copy at reading size is made for the catalogue. The master is never edited, cropped or rotated after capture; if it is wrong, it is rescanned. Corrections to a master are the digital equivalent of writing on the original and are treated with exactly the same seriousness by everyone, without exception.

A note on volunteers' own photographs. There is no rule against photographing a striking document for one's own interest, but such photographs are personal copies and are not to be posted publicly, shared with researchers, or passed off as the archive's images.

Masters are kept in three places: on the workroom computer, on the external disk in the strong room safe, and on the disk that the treasurer keeps at home. The two disks are swapped on the first Saturday of the month at the same time as the water alarm is tested, and the swap is signed on the same sheet, by the same hand, at the same time. Storage that lives in a single place is not storage but a hope, and the archive lost the whole of its first year of scanning in 2009 by hoping rather than checking.

The annual report is one side of paper and is read aloud at the town meeting in March. It states how many accessions arrived, how many boxes were catalogued, how many visitors and enquiries were served, what was digitised, and what went wrong. The last item is the one people remember and the one the committee is most tempted to soften. It is left as written, because a report that admits no failures is not believed about its successes either, and it should not be.

Finally, the notes themselves. They are revised every few years by whoever is doing the most work at the time, and each revision is dated and kept, so that a future volunteer can see not only what the rules are but how they came to be. A rule that nobody can explain is a rule that will be quietly dropped, and most of the rules here were paid for by a loss that somebody once had to stand up and explain to the town, in person, at the meeting in March, when the report was read aloud.

Requests to reproduce an image in print or online go to the committee with the reference number and the intended use, and permission is given freely to anyone who credits the archive and refused to anyone who will not. There is no fee for private or educational use and a modest one for commercial use, set each year and printed on the request form. The point of the fee is not income. It is that a publisher who has paid for an image tends to caption it correctly and to send the archive a copy of the book, and both of those things matter more than the money. The credit line is printed on the request form too, and the committee checks each spring that it was used.